



Smart Phone

Alcatel 525

Price: Rs 9,995 **B**

The 525 is a small and compact phone that looks a bit outdated, and feels like a soap bar with little aesthetic appeal. The display is extremely small, the keypad cramped and the buttons really hard to press. Though Alcatel provides three different face plates, none of them look appealing.

The menu structure is uninspiring and does not offer an intuitive interface; this is further complicated by the hard, rectangular three-way joystick meant for navigating through the menu. The keypad is cramped and the keys lack the tactility and are at times, unresponsive. A high-resolution small LCD screen forms the display that is capable of displaying three lines of text at a time. A bright blue backlight provides the night vision capabilities.

The phone comes with 250 capacity entry book, and lacks group SMS and SMS chat support. It comes bundled with a calculator, currency converter, three games and two phone line support. The presence of voice dialling, voice commands and voice memo capabilities are an obvious advantage. It also does away with calendaring options, but one can key in reminders into the alarm menu that rings even when the phone is switched off.

The phone comes with WAP 1.2.1 support and GPRS for high speed connectivity, but sorely misses an IrDA port. It has poor signal reception, due to which the voice clarity and quality is significantly hampered. The phone comes with a Lithium-ion power pack that gives it a maximum of three-day standby time.

Overall, this is an outdated model that neither charms the buyer with looks, nor features, but still costs Rs 9,995.

Alcatel 715

Price: Rs 14,995 **B+**

Alcatel has tried to break into the high-end phone market with this well-researched handset. The 715 is a sleek, oblong, rectangular phone with a large LCD display that takes up the upper three quarters of the entire length. The phone comes in four basic colours; the one we reviewed sported a combination of light grey and silver imparting it a sedate, business look.

The keypad that takes up the remaining one-third of the phone surface, is quite large, and the buttons are well spaced out. All the keys are very responsive except for the five-way joystick, which is hard and tacky. A shortcut key placed on the sides can be personalised to bring up the most frequently used menu.

The large LCD display is capable of displaying seven lines of text and the font size can be increased and decreased according to preference. However, the display isn't as crisp as it should be and the screen appears faded out.

Alcatel has used an icon-based menu structure that can be navigated conveniently using the five-way joystick. The phone

book has space for 800 entries and you can even create up to 13 directories (four directories by default) in the memory, and assign each group with a different ring tone. Also, the contact information is very comprehensive with ability to record the name, surname, job profile, two e-mail addresses, postal address and a text note. Similarly, the calendar is also extremely detailed and functional, yet simple to use. The phone supports SMS, EMS, voice-dialling, voice-commands and also doubles as a dictaphone; not to mention it has the mandatory, calculator, currency converter and alarm clock. It comes with polyphonic ring tones and an external composer that can be loaded onto a PC. One of the joys of the 715 is playing games on it—the screen display rotates 90 degrees, giving it a handheld games console feel.

Apart from these features, the 715 comes with WAP 1.2.1 support for browsing the Internet. On the data connectivity front, it is provided with an IrDA port and GPRS support. It has a handsome, one week of standby battery time. In our tests, the phone showed excellent signal reception, speech and voice clarity.

To sum it all, the Alcatel 715 is a good phone that is stuffed with practical planning features. The menu takes some time to get used to, but once done, you won't touch any other phone. However, it can do with a better navigation keys. Priced at Rs 14,995, it is slightly expensive, especially when pitted against the Sony Ericsson T68i.



Motorola A388

Price: Rs 19,995 **B**

Although this phone breaks the Rs 18,000 barrier set for the Smart phone category, it still finds itself here. This is because of the limited set of features that this cell phone possesses. We did not think it appropriate to let it compete with the entrants in the Also a phone category.

The A388 believes in the new age mantra of enmeshing various information technology products to come up with an all-in-one solution. It combines the usability of a cell phone with the functionality of a PDA. Weighing 130 grams, it's a heavy phone, but that is justified by the extra hardware that makes it a PDA. The build quality is commendable, the phone feels rugged and solid. Open the flap and you will immediately notice that something's missing—a keypad! Motorola has made the screen into an input device, by using a touch screen. The phone comes with a large, standard, crisp LCD

